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The Moncton Transcript (Moncton, Moncton Parish, New Brunswick, Canada) · Fri, Aug 17, 1956 · Page 4
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COPPER DEPOSIT — The current high price for copper has spurred exploration and development in British Columbia. This photo shows drillers and mining officials surveying a test trench in the province's Highland Valley 200 miles northeast of Vancouver. In their hunt for copper, miners dig a long trench of increasing depth to show the strata at various stages across the property. The dark layers seen here may carry the metal-bearing ore.—(CP Photo)

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Large Copper Mining Development Being Carried On In B. C.

BY BRUCE LEVETT

VANCOUVER (CP)—Copper-mining development in British Columbia is being carried on from Vancouver Island on the west to the western foothills of the Rocky Mountains and from the Yukon on the north to the United States border.

Much of the activity is the result of the current high copper price and some is long-range planning in a capricious market.

Most B.C. mining men see the price of copper, which hit a level above 50 cents a pound earlier in the year, firming at between 30 and 35 cents. They predict it will be the mines which can operate in that range that will prosper.

Men in the industry point to the Copper Mountain Mine of Granby Consolidated Mining, Smelting and Power Co., Ltd., as an example.

Second Quarter Off

An old mine with 40 levels and a conveyer which dumps the slag eight miles from the diggings, Copper Mountain showed a net profit of $259,935—or 57 cents a share—for the first six months of 1956.

Net profit in the first quarter was $241,718 or 53 cents a share. In the second quarter it had dropped to $18,215.

Granby announced that a recent decline in the price of the red metal was curtailing the search for new ore at the mine site just east of Princeton, B.C.

Copper Mountain, operating on low-grade ore, came close to curtailing operations a year ago but the high price made it profitable to run slag back through the mill with new ore to recover the little copper missed previously. When the price dropped, it was no longer profitable.

However, the semi-annual report had two optimistic announcements.

One was that developments are "continuing in a satisfactory manner" at Granduc, a long-range, $50,000,000 project near the Yukon border.

The other reported that small but profitable operation may be conducted on company property at Phoenix, B.C., in the boundary country near Greenwood and Grand Forks, B.C. Granby took 285,000,000 pounds of copper out of the operation there between 1900 and 1919. When the company pulled out the following year, the city became a ghost town.

A concentrator is planned to treat 500 tons of ore a day near the old workings and to extract the remaining ore by open-pit methods. Production is expected to begin in 1957. The plant will be built, as far as possible, with surplus equipment from the Copper Mountain Mine.

North American copper prices, lower than those quoted on the world market, began to climb as stocks dropped due to strikes in Chile and Africa. This was despite fear of a loss of markets through forcing fabricators to use more economical substitutes.

Oswood MacDonald, of Cowichan Copper on Vancouver Island, says:

"Nobody can predict what the price of copper is going to do. We have to be prepared to operate as economically as possible." With a reserve of stock and cash in the bank, Mr. MacDonald says, his property is making money shipping high-grade—6.2 per cent—ore to the Tacoma, Wash., smelter before the mine is even in production.

Cowichan, he says, is in the process of proving up its high-grade deposits and rather than dump the tailings from its adit tunnels, the rock is shipped away to provide funds for continued development. He forecasts that there will be six large producers on Vancouver Island within two years.

Cowichan is on the site of the old Blue Grouse Mine which was partially developed more than 30 years ago.

Highland Valley Claims

Another consolidation of old claims is the Highland valley, bounded by Merritt, Ashcroft and Kamloops, 300 miles northeast of Vancouver, where a dozen firms are carrying out exploration and development work.

One of the largest is the Bethlehem Copper property, which plans an open-pit operation in the Snowstorm Mountain and Forge Mountain areas.

However, little is known of the quality of ore on the Bethlehem property as American Smelting and Refining Co., carrying out a detailed drilling program, has announced no assays.

Bill Fletcher, business editor of the Vancouver Sun, in a column on the valley, says:

"It's hard to consider it a fly-by-night hot spot when outfits like Kennecott Copper, As and R, Chimo, Mogul and Draper Dobie have shown firm interest in different properties."

Some of the old diggings have lain dormant for nearly 40 years through a variety of reasons—price, grade and tonnage, mainly. In some places transportation was a problem before the railroads came through. In others there were snow and exploration problems. These are licked today by helicopters and snow tractors.

Nuisance Now Asset

Another consideration was that in some places—Highland valley for one—molybdenum is present in the store. At one time this was considered a nuisance as smelters were not equipped to extract it if it was present in quantity.

Now, with modern extraction methods, molybdenum has become a $1.10-a-pound asset.

British Columbia's copper production has been climbing steadily—49,021,013 pounds in 1953 to 50,150,087 pounds in 1954. No figures are available for 1955.

Despite the increase, the value dropped—to $14,599,693 in 1954 from $14,869,544 in 1953.

As a copper producer British Columbia ranks fourth among the Canadian provinces behind Ontario, Quebec and Saskatchewan.

Throughout the industry the word is the same—it will be at least two years before any big development is proven and in production.

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